

The Lighthouse at Sker Point

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Reader test document - QA fixture

1. The Keeper's Ledger

Maren wrote the log in a hand so small it looked like a line of ants. The wind had been steady for nine days, and the entries repeated themselves: clear at four, clear at eight, nothing on the horizon.

She had inherited the ledger with the post. Nobody had explained the job, only the objects - a brass key, a tin of wick, a book with a leather spine and no title. The keeper's rule was simple and unwritten: the light does not go out.

On the eleventh day the wind changed direction, and with it came a sound she had never heard before, low and patient, like something large moving slowly under the water of the sound.

2. Fog on the Sound

Fog arrived without ceremony. It simply was there at noon, a soft grey wall that swallowed the harbour and then the last hundred metres of rock below the tower.

In fog the work became ritual. Wick trimmed, lens polished, clock wound, log signed. Maren found she liked the ritual. It gave the hours an order the fog had taken away.

She talked to the sea a little. It was not madness, exactly; it was the ordinary courtesy of living alone with something that listens. The sea never answered, but it never left either.

3. What the Lamp Recorded

The lens was a machine of brass and glass that turned on a clockwork drum. Maren cleaned it the way she imagined her grandmother had, with a soft cloth and a great deal of patience.

Behind the glass the flame flattened and widened. She wrote down the time, the weather, the number of ships that answered. The numbers mattered. Somebody, somewhere, was reading them.

That night a ship answered. Three short flashes, meaning all well. Maren wrote it down, and then sat for a while in the dark, letting the beam go over her face again and again.

4. The Long Dark Interval

The dark interval began on a Thursday and lasted four days. The generator failed, the spare coil was corroded, and the road was under water.

She trimmed wick by hand every four hours through the long nights, moving the lamp with a rope and a shoulder, holding the light on the channel the way she had been taught - a foot left of the marker, no more, no less.

The ships kept coming in. She counted nine of them, and she never once wrote the word failure in the ledger, because it had not happened. The light was still there. That was the whole of the job.

5. A Light Kept Anyway

The relief boat came in spring. Maren handed over the key, the tin, and the book with the leather spine, and said nothing about the eleven days of wind or the ship that answered.

The new keeper read the ledger for a long time. At the entry for the thirty- first night he stopped and looked up, and Maren told him what she had done with the rope, and the foot left of the marker.

Then she walked up the path to the bus, carrying nothing much, in a coat that smelled of oil and salt. Behind her the lamp turned, and kept turning, and the light did not go out.

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